infantry companies who fought with ‘a variety of exotic weapons like two-handed swords, halberds, and massive war clubs’. These men also carried shields, sometimes so large that they covered the body entirely. The vanguard of the rana, led by Hakim Sur Pathan, then attacked the Mughal cavalry led by Raja Jagannath and Asaf Khan. The Mughal horses struggled on the sharp, broken ground as the armies clashed. Just as Raja Jagannath was in danger of being killed, the Mughal vanguard arrived, led by Man Singh on a war elephant. Ever more warriors streamed out of the ravines and the gullies, with slashing blades and screaming fire.

Rana Pratap’s left wing was led with great courage by Raja Ram Shah of Gwalior who died that day on the blood-soaked battlefield, flanked by his three sons, all of whom laid down their lives for the rana. The opposing right wing of the Mughals was led by Ghazi Khan Badakshi and Rai Loonkarn along with a number of shaikhzadas from Sikri. As the sun rose inexorably higher on this churning ochre battlefield, Mughal scimitars and Persian shamshirs clashed with straight Rajput talwars and broadswords. The horses whirled and whinnied in their armour, sweat darkening their heated bodies. The foot soldiers swung their maces and battleaxes and thrust their katars at each other. Most dangerous of all were the mounted archers of the Mughals, who were deadly in close combat. They could fire the composite bow at full gallop or swing a sword or throw a lance and were ‘arguably the most formidable individual warrior on any battlefield’, according to Andrew de la Garza. At one point, the Rajputs on the Mughal side got so hopelessly entangled with the Mewar warriors that Badauni shouted out to Asaf Khan under the molten sun: ‘How are we in these circumstances to distinguish between friendly and hostile Rajputs?’ To which Asaf Khan joyfully yelled back, ‘[T]hey will experience the whiz of the arrows, be what may. On whichever side they may be killed it will be a gain to Islam.’

Elephants on both sides also joined the battle, trumpeting loudly and swinging their sharpened tusks. But there was an even deadlier aspect to the war elephants of the Mughals. Akbar had understood the need for smaller, easily portable guns and the most ingenious artillery developed was the chaturnal, or so-called ‘camel gun’. This was a swivel gun attached by a harness to the side of a camel or elephant, where it could be operated by a gunner and fired in any direction. The larger of these weapons could fire ‘lead shots the size of baseballs’ and a contingent of camel gunners, unique